

SHIVKISHAN AGARWAL⁶⁷ RAJENDRA AGARWAL⁴² AVIN AGARWAL²¹

PACKAGED FOOD MANUFACTURERS
CHAIRMAN & DIRECTORS, HALDIRAM'S
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1933 Rs 500
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,000 crore

(FROM LEFT) RAJENDRA AGARWAL, SHIVKISHAN AGARWAL AND AVIN AGARWAL AT THEIR NAGPUR OFFICE



PANKAJ TIWARI

SNACK CHARMERS

success MANTRA

Quality and a keen understanding of the diverse Indian market

biggest CHALLENGE

When MNCs tried to take over the traditional snacks market in the '90s

role MODEL

The late Haldiram Agarwal, who turned a product into a brand

It's a salty savoury any halwai in Rajasthan's crowded markets can rustle up. How then can you take the humble *aloo bhujia* and build a Rs 1,000-crore brand around it? Ask the redoubtable Haldiram Agarwal's fifth-generation progeny and the answer is simple. It's Quality with a capital Q. Starting 75 years ago, they moved from selling packaged bhujia in Bikaner to Kolkata in 1952 where they transformed *rasmullas* into India's largest-selling branded Bengali delicacy.

Since then, parts of the family have moved to Delhi and Nagpur. Shivkishan Agarwal, 67, chairman of the Nagpur branch says, "It's all about reading the market and maintaining the highest standards of quality." With over 100 Indian products, they had the goods to go global. Today, his branch with a turnover of Rs 350 crore is exporting products worth Rs 30 crore to countries with large Indian immigrant populations like US, UK and Canada.

"We now want to focus on overseas markets," says Avin Agarwal, 21, fifth-generation grandson of Haldiram and the director, Nagpur branch. However, products such as Takatak, which takes on market leader Kurkure, have not met with the success of their traditional products. So, is Haldiram's just a one-dimensional brand? "No," insists Avin, explaining that even in the past, there were hiccups before something clicked, like their son papdi which has now made a mark in the southern market.

Realising that the market for their traditional Indian products would eventually peak and then plateau, Haldiram's is now trying its hand not just at the bakery and milk products but at Western snacks and beverages too. With its core business going from strength to strength, it's time to try some packaged Western snacks like chips and biscuits. The fifth generation, it seems, is a chip of the old Haldiram block.

by Ambresh Mishra